



PTI PHOTO

FIRST MOVE: Nath (centre)

Karnataka, a section of the leadership feels that this would only promote factionalism. The decision is easier in states like Delhi where the Congress is ruling and the sitting chief minister automatically leads the campaign. But even here, the Congress initially toyed with Ajay Maken's candidature before finally deciding to stay with Sheila Dikshit. In Chhattisgarh, 10 Janpath loyalist Ajit Jogi stands a stronger chance than the itinerant V.C. Shukla.

Though he has been campaigning in the state for the past few months, and unofficially heads the campaign, he is yet to be nominated for the job.

In Rajasthan, General Secretary Ashok Gehlot has made it clear that he wants to lead the campaign but has not been given a green signal despite the fact that it needs a strong name to counter Vasundhara Raje. With the states slated for polls in November, the Congress does not have much time to get its strategy straight. **by Priya Sahgal**

SIGNPOSTS

ARRESTED: Shahbaz Hussain, the main suspect in the Jaipur blasts case. He was running a computer centre in Lucknow.

SWORN IN: JMM President



Shibu Soren as the sixth chief minister of Jharkhand. He succeeds Madhu Koda.

LAUNCHED: Telugu superstar Chiranjeevi's political party Prajaraajyam in Tirupati. He had decided to enter politics in August.

DEFERRED: The Champions Trophy, which was to be held in Pakistan, till October 2009 by the ICC. Pakistan had failed to address the security concerns of the participating countries. The decision came 19 days before the tournament was to start.

ANNOUNCED: A Code of Ethics and Broadcasting Standards for the country's news channels by the News Broadcasters' Association.

The Chosen One

DELHI In faction-ridden Madhya Pradesh, Commerce Minister Kamal Nath pulled off the impossible. At a massive rally in Chhindwara recently, the Congress leaders from the state got together to announce his name as the party's chief ministerial face. Though there has been no official announcement, the name was okayed by state heavyweights like Digvijay Singh, Arjun Singh's son Ajay Singh and even chief ministerial aspirants like Jyotiraditya Scindia and

Suresh Pachouri. When Pachouri was sent to head the state party unit six months ago, he was tipped for the top job. But the lightweight leader could not assert himself over the other chieftains. A seven-term Lok Sabha member, the more politically savvy Nath should have no problem on that front.

Nath's nomination comes at a time when the Congress is still debating the merits of announcing a chief ministerial candidate before the polls. After poll debacles in Gujarat and

VIS-A-VIS RATAN TATA Tata Group chairman **versus** MAMATA BANERJEE Trinamool Congress chief

I want to understand why the Tata Group is unwanted in West Bengal. If there is this feeling, we will exit the state.



SAURABH SINGH

Who is indulging in violence? I am not responsible for such a situation. People who have lost their land have to be taken care of.

EPILOGUE: If the current imbroglio does not end, West Bengal may have to say Tata to industrialisation.